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# 1971–1991: Interventions and Alignment

## Alignment: Tilting to the Soviet Union, 1971–1991

In many respects, India's approach to the last two decades of the Cold War —from 1971 to 1991—was different from the preceding quarter century. Geopolitically, the United States and China began to drift closer, driven by shared concerns about the Soviet Union. Their relationship, midwifed with the help of Pakistan, was consolidated by US Secretary of State Henry Kissinger's secret visit to China, followed by President Richard Nixon's historic trip in 1971. The People's Republic of China was welcomed into the United Nations as a permanent member of the UN Security Council and normal diplomatic ties were established between Washington and Beijing by the late 1970s. From India's standpoint, the US, China, and Pakistan were now perceived to constitute a dangerous coalition. Further developments took place domestically. While the first half of India's Cold War-era foreign policy had been dominated by Jawaharlal Nehru's personality and worldview, the second half saw the strong imprint of Indira Gandhi. Economically, India remained relatively closed, even as other Asian economies became more globally integrated. Security challenges, including separatism and terrorism, intensified.

As a consequence, India's foreign relations during the 1970s and 1980s had two cardinal features. One was an open alignment with the Soviet Union following a Treaty of Peace and Friendship signed in 1971, in part to guard against the prospect of Chinese or American intervention in the Bangladesh Liberation War. While continuing with the rhetorical use of Non-Alignment, in practice India enjoyed much closer political, security, and economic ties with the Soviet Union than with the United States.